

Greek architectural sculpture

Greek architects used a complex mix of optical illusions, ratios and rigid structural rules. The overall appearance of their buildings was intentionally simple, but sculptural decorations were often elaborate. Forming a key element of many temples and monuments, they featured on column capitals and pediments, in friezes and as statues.

Exterior sculpture usually featured in the metopes and triglyphs (two alternating panel types) of the entablature, the roof-supporting structure that sat across the columns. Some late Doric temples featured a continuous frieze around the outer wall of the cella (inner temple chamber), but the Ionic period, from the mid-sixth century BCE, brought more intricate decorations, including reliefs that often showed historical or mythological narratives. Around the Parthenon's cella, a low-relief frieze depicts the people of Athens in a Panathenaic procession, a key local celebration. Greek buildings and sculpture were always vividly painted, and often further embellished with metal accessories.

